

I Heard About Menstrual Cups at 18. So Why Didn't I Try One?

What one personal hesitation reveals about consumer adoption, trust and the difficulty of changing menstrual habits in India.

I heard about menstrual cups when I was 18. A few of my friends told me about menstrual cups and how easy they were to use. I was curious. But I still couldn't bring myself to try one.

My first thought was: "Will it be painful?" The product itself looked intimidating. I didn't know how insertion would work, whether it would hurt, or whether I would even be able to use it correctly.

And there was another problem. Even if I decided to try one, I wasn't sure I could convince my mother. She wasn't even aware that such a product existed.

So instead of buying one, I did what many curious consumers do when a product feels unfamiliar: I started looking it up.

That experience made me wonder: if menstrual cups are repeatedly described as convenient, reusable and sustainable, why haven't they become a mainstream menstrual product?

The more I looked into it, the more interesting the problem became. It wasn't simply a question of whether the product worked. It was a question of adoption.

01 — The product exists. The adoption gap does too

Menstrual cups have been available in India for years, yet they remain a small part of the menstrual-care landscape.

Findings from India's Fifth National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), as cited in the original research draft, show that among women aged 15–24:

- **64.4%** reported using sanitary pads
- **49.6%** reported using cloth
- **15%** reported using homemade napkins
- Only **0.3%** reported using menstrual cups

The numbers raise a consumer question: why does awareness of a product not automatically translate into adoption?

This is what makes menstrual cups an interesting consumer problem. The barriers are not necessarily concentrated at one point. They can appear throughout the adoption journey.

02 — Awareness is not adoption

A study conducted in Karnataka, cited in the draft, found that nearly 82% of participants had good awareness of menstrual cups, while only 2.6% had actually used one.

Once a consumer knows the product exists, the questions change:

- Is it safe?
- Will it hurt?
- How exactly do I use it?
- What if it gets stuck?
- Is insertion uncomfortable?
- Is it hygienic?
- Will I be able to use it correctly?
- What will my family think?
- Who can I ask if something goes wrong?

The product is no longer competing only against another product. It is competing against uncertainty.

03 — The incumbent isn't just a product. It's a habit

For many women, menstrual care isn't a decision they consciously reconsider every month. The product is already familiar. You know how to use it. You know where to buy it. You know what to expect.

Your mother may have used it. Your friends may use it. There is no learning curve.

A menstrual cup, on the other hand, asks the consumer to learn something new. And learning something new in a highly personal context comes with friction.

The fundamental consumer problem is therefore broader than product preference: the cup isn't just asking consumers to switch products. It is asking them to change a behaviour.

04 — The first-use problem

The first experience matters disproportionately. A study cited in the research draft found that 23% of women reported insertion and initial use of the menstrual cup as challenging and uncomfortable.

For someone who has never used an internal menstrual product, the first attempt can involve uncertainty about how to fold, how to insert, how far to insert, whether it is positioned correctly and how to remove it.

Every additional step creates another opportunity to abandon the product.

The same cited study reported that after using the cup regularly, more than 90% of women found it convenient and recommended it to others.

The adoption journey can therefore be viewed as:

Before use: uncertainty → **First use:** friction → **Regular use:** familiarity → **Familiarity:** perceived convenience

For a consumer category with a learning curve, the challenge is not only communicating the end-state benefit. It is helping the consumer navigate the experience of trying something unfamiliar.

05 — The consumer is evaluating more than functionality

A traditional product comparison might focus on functional trade-offs:

- **Pads:** familiar and easy to use; potential concerns include discomfort, waste and allergies.
- **Tampons:** convenient and discreet; concerns cited in the draft include TSS, dryness and recurring cost.
- **Menstrual cups:** reusable and high capacity; the major friction point is insertion and the learning curve.

But consumers do not evaluate intimate products on functionality alone. They also evaluate perceived risk.

A consumer may think: "It might be safe, but I don't know how to use it." That uncertainty can be enough to stop the purchase.

06 — My mother was part of the adoption problem

Looking back, my hesitation wasn't purely personal. It was also social.

I wasn't just asking, "Can I use this?" I was also asking, "Can I introduce this product into my household?" My mother didn't know what a menstrual cup was.

That means the consumer who discovers the product isn't necessarily the only person involved in adoption. In some households, menstrual products are not completely individual purchasing decisions.

07 — The household is part of the market

Parents can influence what younger women are comfortable trying. Doctors influence perceptions of safety. Friends influence discovery. Social media influences curiosity. Communities influence normalisation.

This creates an important distinction between **the target user** and **the decision influencer**. A young woman may be the eventual user, but in semi-urban households, parental trust can materially shape whether she feels comfortable experimenting with an unfamiliar menstrual product.

That is why the go-to-market strategy cannot stop at reaching young women on digital platforms. It has to address the household-level trust that sits around the user.

08 — A different GTM opportunity: reach the user and the mother

In semi-urban markets, menstrual product adoption may be influenced not only by awareness but by household-level trust, particularly from parents. Traditional digital marketing may therefore have limited effectiveness in segments where the mother or family remains an important decision influencer.

A more distinctive approach is to take menstrual-health education into mainstream entertainment and regional content that mothers already consume.

Mother-daughter storytelling

Instead of presenting menstrual cups as a product advertisement, mainstream television serials and regional content can introduce the topic through familiar household situations. A mother-daughter conversation about menstrual products, for example, can make an unfamiliar product part of an ordinary family discussion.

Doctor-led guidance within entertainment

Doctor or healthcare-professional characters can address questions around safety, use and hygiene within the storyline. This can provide a layer of credibility without forcing the audience into a conventional educational campaign.

Regional-language normalisation

Regional content can carry menstrual-health narratives beyond English-speaking digital communities. The objective is not to tell the audience to buy immediately, but to make the subject less unfamiliar and the conversation easier to have at home.

Why mothers matter

The mother can function as a trust bridge between awareness and trial. If the person who influences household decisions understands the product, the young consumer may face less resistance when she considers trying it.

This reframes the audience strategy from “young women as customers” to “young women as users + mothers as important trust and decision influencers.”

09 — Trust becomes part of the product

For a product with a learning curve, education is not simply marketing. It becomes part of the product experience.

A first-time consumer may need demonstrations, credible explanations, reassurance around safety, clear instructions, answers to uncomfortable questions, testimonials from relatable users, access to trusted professionals and someone to ask when the first attempt doesn't go perfectly.

The onboarding experience can therefore matter almost as much as the physical product.

10 — The social layer of adoption

There is another barrier that doesn't appear on a product specification sheet: stigma.

Menstruation itself remains a sensitive topic. Now introduce a product that requires consumers to think and talk about insertion. The psychological barrier can increase.

This is why simply saying “menstrual cups are sustainable” may not be enough. Sustainability is a long-term benefit; the immediate question may be, “But will I be comfortable using this on my next period?”

The immediate problem has to be addressed before the long-term benefit can influence behaviour.

11 — Sustainability has to compete with immediate friction

The environmental argument for reusable menstrual products is compelling. But consumers rarely adopt products solely because they are better for the environment. They adopt when the personal value proposition is strong enough.

For a menstrual cup, that value proposition can combine:

- Comfort
- Convenience
- Confidence
- Safety
- Economics
- Sustainability

If the first experience is intimidating, sustainability may not be enough to overcome the friction.

This creates a broader go-to-market lesson: a product's strongest macro benefit does not necessarily solve the consumer's most immediate problem.

12 — Where does the consumer actually drop off?

The adoption funnel can be visualised as:

Awareness — “I've heard about menstrual cups.”

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Curiosity — “What exactly is it?”

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Consideration — “Could I use one?”

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Purchase — “Should I actually buy one?”

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First use — “Can I insert and remove it comfortably?”

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Familiarisation — “Am I getting better at using it?”

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Adoption — “This is convenient enough to continue.”

The key business question is therefore not simply how to generate awareness. It is how to reduce the friction that appears between curiosity, household acceptance, first use and continued use.

13 — The adoption problem may be bigger than the product problem

When a category has low penetration, the instinct is often to improve the product: make it more comfortable, easier to insert or better designed.

But the bottleneck can exist around the product: education, trust, first experience, support and habit formation.

A technically strong product can still struggle against an alternative that is familiar if the switching cost feels too high.

14 — What should a company actually solve?

If menstrual cups are viewed as a consumer business, the question is not simply: “How do we convince more women to use menstrual cups?”

A more useful framing is: “How do we reduce the psychological and practical friction between curiosity and confident first use?”

Product — Can first-time use be made less intimidating?

Education — Can instructions answer the questions a first-time user is afraid to ask?

Trust — Can credible people—doctors, educators or experienced users—reduce perceived risk?

Community — Can women hear from people who have actually gone through the transition?

Family — Can the product be normalised within households rather than positioned as a secret individual decision?

Content — Can education show the actual experience instead of simply listing benefits?

15 — The GTM is part of the product

For a category with a behavioural barrier, distribution cannot be separated completely from education.

- Digital-first channels can create discovery.
- Influencers can demonstrate normalised usage.
- Doctors and medical professionals can provide credibility.
- Community-based education can address questions consumers may hesitate to search publicly.
- **Mother-daughter conversations can reduce household resistance.**
- **Regional entertainment content can reach consumers beyond English-speaking digital communities.**

The objective isn’t simply “Buy a menstrual cup.” It is a broader journey:

Understand → Trust → Try → Learn → Continue using

16 — The bigger consumer insight

My initial assumption was simple. Maybe menstrual cups aren’t mainstream because people don’t know enough about them.

But the research made me reconsider that. If awareness can coexist with low usage, awareness alone is not sufficient. And if first-time users can experience difficulty while regular users later report convenience, the category has to think about the transition into use—not only the end-state benefit.

Consumers are being asked to cross a behavioural gap: from something familiar to something unfamiliar. The wider that gap feels, the more support the consumer needs.

17 — What this means for the category

The menstrual cup category doesn’t necessarily need consumers to believe that pads are bad. It needs consumers to believe that trying something new is manageable.

That creates an opportunity to move from **product education** to **adoption education**.

Not only: “Here are the benefits of a menstrual cup.” But: “Here’s what happens when you try one for the first time, here’s what may feel unfamiliar, here’s how you navigate it, and here’s how familiarity can change the experience.”

Final Thought

When I first heard about menstrual cups at 18, I thought my problem was simply fear: fear of pain, insertion, doing something wrong, or explaining it at home.

But perhaps the more useful consumer insight is that unfamiliarity creates a need for support. The product may not be fighting another product alone. It may be fighting habit, uncertainty, social conditioning and a lack of trusted information.

That is what makes menstrual cups an interesting consumer case. Sometimes the question isn’t “Why isn’t the consumer buying this?” It is: “What has to become true before the consumer feels comfortable trying it?”

For menstrual cups, that may be the difference between a product people have heard about and a product they actually adopt.